Module 10 Individual Assignment: Visual Design Critique

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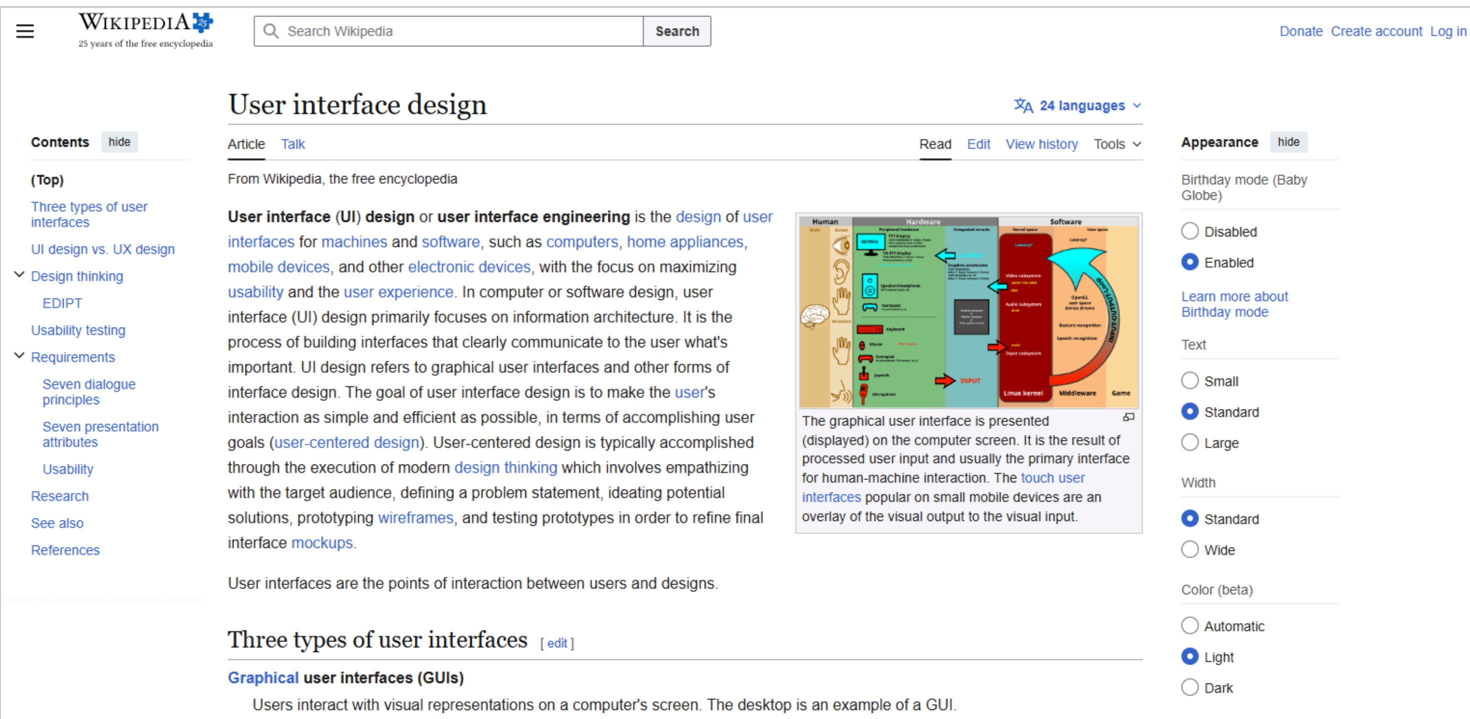
Website: Wikipedia

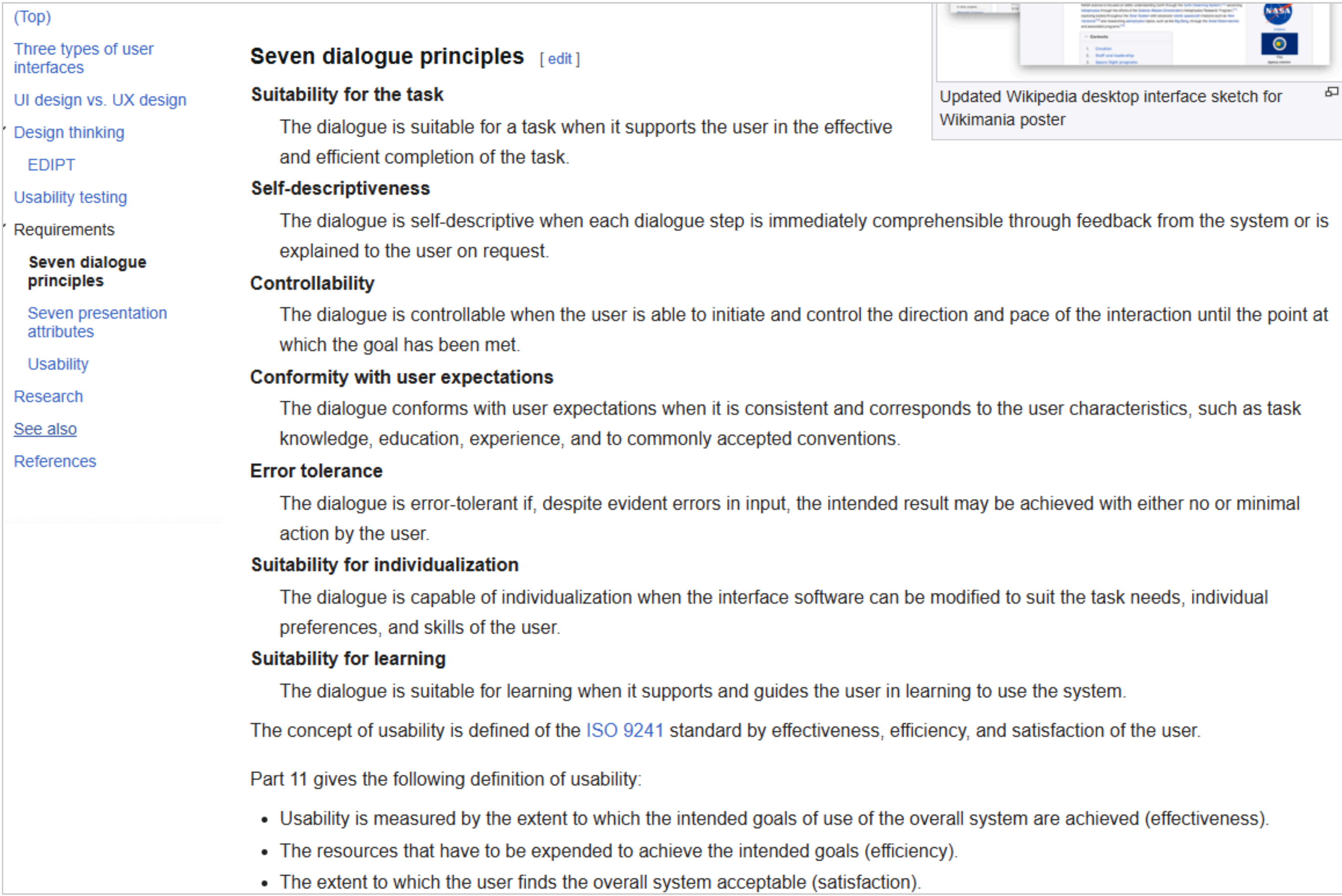
I will be looking at Wikipedia, as it is a site most people are familiar with and it contains a variety of content types (body text, infoboxes, navigation elements, settings panels) that make it useful for examining visual design principles. I specifically chose the "User Interface Design" article as I thought it would be ironic. Here are seven instances of how the site follows or violates visual design principles from Module 10.

1. No Clear Focal Point (Violates Emphasis)



When you first arrive at a Wikipedia article, the title, introductory paragraph, infobox image, table of contents, and navigation tabs are all presented at roughly the same visual weight. The emphasis principle states that a design should establish a focal point, a visually distinct area that guides the user's eye to the most important content. Wikipedia does not establish this. Every major element competes for attention equally, so the user has no visual cue about where to begin reading. Because there is no element that stands out as the clear entry point, the emphasis principle is violated.

2. Weak Visual Distinction Between Sections (Violates Hierarchy)



Seven dialogue principles [edit]

Updated Wikipedia desktop interface sketch for Wikimania poster

Suitability for the task

The dialogue is suitable for a task when it supports the user in the effective and efficient completion of the task.

Self-descriptiveness

The dialogue is self-descriptive when each dialogue step is immediately comprehensible through feedback from the system or is explained to the user on request.

Controllability

The dialogue is controllable when the user is able to initiate and control the direction and pace of the interaction until the point at which the goal has been met.

Conformity with user expectations

The dialogue conforms with user expectations when it is consistent and corresponds to the user characteristics, such as task knowledge, education, experience, and to commonly accepted conventions.

Error tolerance

The dialogue is error-tolerant if, despite evident errors in input, the intended result may be achieved with either no or minimal action by the user.

Suitability for individualization

The dialogue is capable of individualization when the interface software can be modified to suit the task needs, individual preferences, and skills of the user.

Suitability for learning

The dialogue is suitable for learning when it supports and guides the user in learning to use the system.

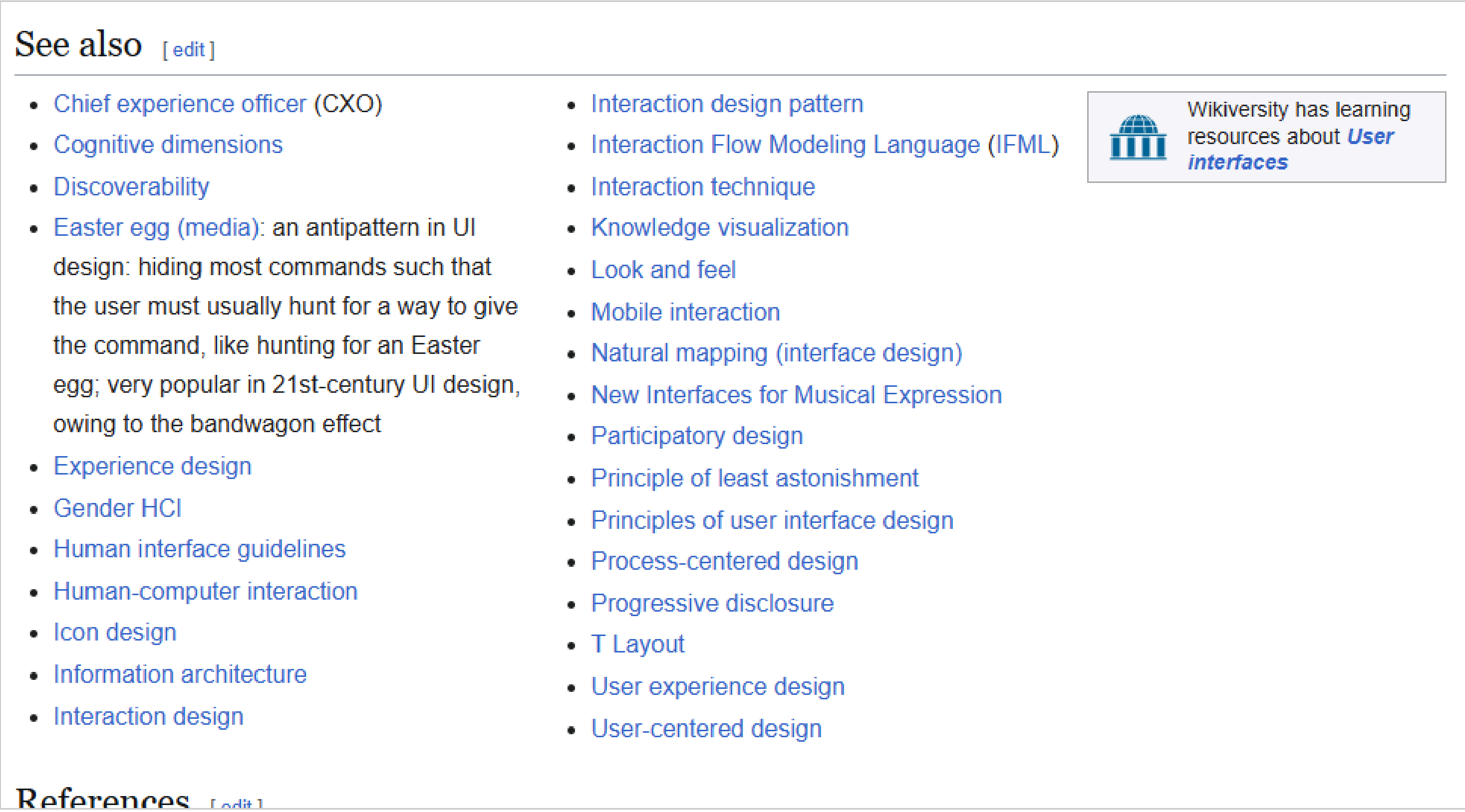
The concept of usability is defined of the ISO 9241 standard by effectiveness, efficiency, and satisfaction of the user.

Part 11 gives the following definition of usability:

- Usability is measured by the extent to which the intended goals of use of the overall system are achieved (effectiveness).
- The resources that have to be expended to achieve the intended goals (efficiency).
- The extent to which the user finds the overall system acceptable (satisfaction).

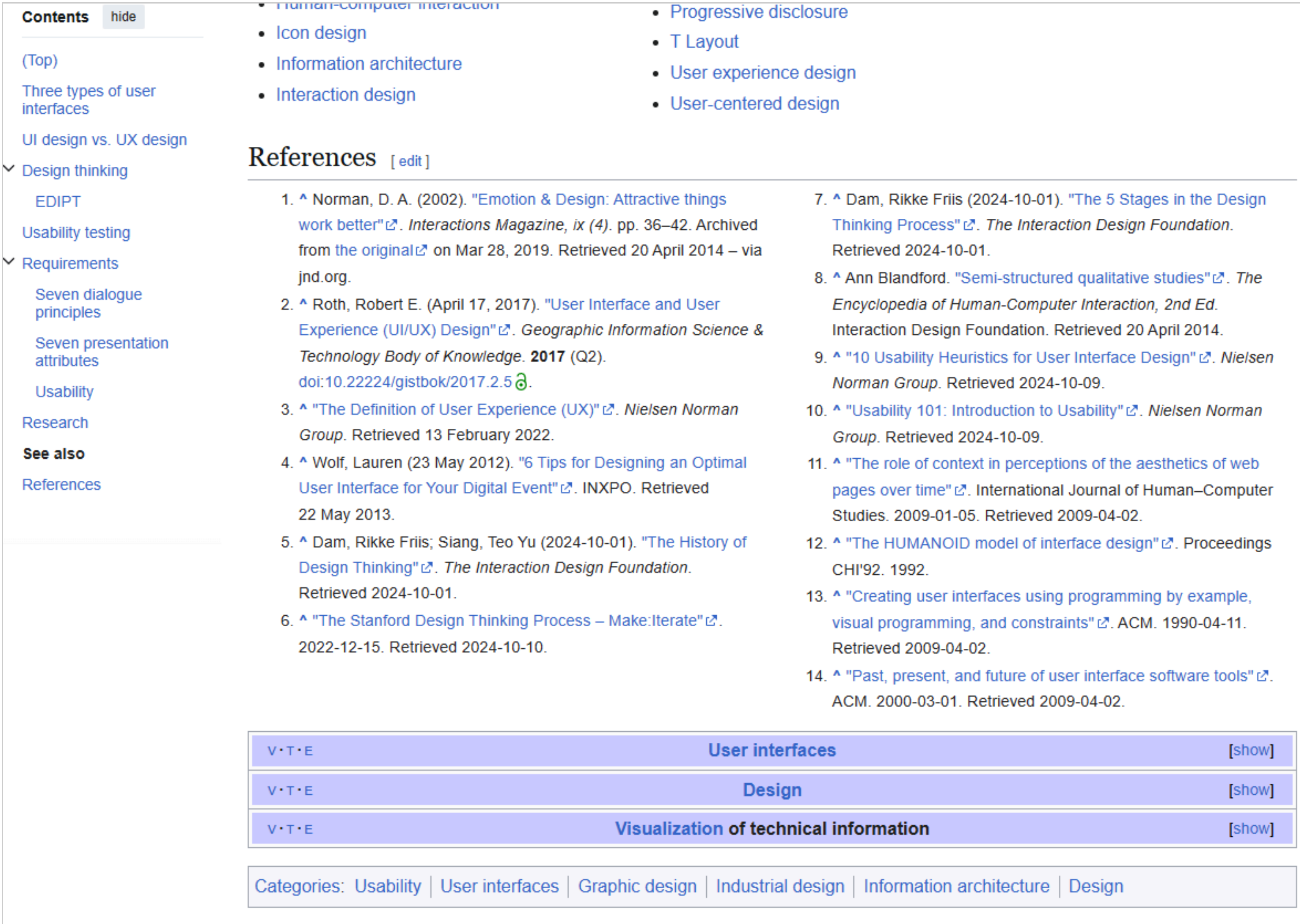
The "Seven dialogue principles" section lists each principle with a bold term followed by a definition. However, the visual difference between the bold term and the surrounding body text is minimal. The hierarchy principle says that groups should be ordered by perceptual prominence to match the intended reading sequence, and that designers should use color and weight rather than just size to create that ordering. Here, the section header, the bold terms, and the definitions all appear at nearly the same visual level. A user trying to scan through the principles has to read each line rather than being able to visually jump between them. It reads more like a bolded list than subsection headers. Because the design does not provide sufficient contrast between heading levels, the hierarchy principle is violated.

3. Unorganized "See Also" Links (Violates Grouping)



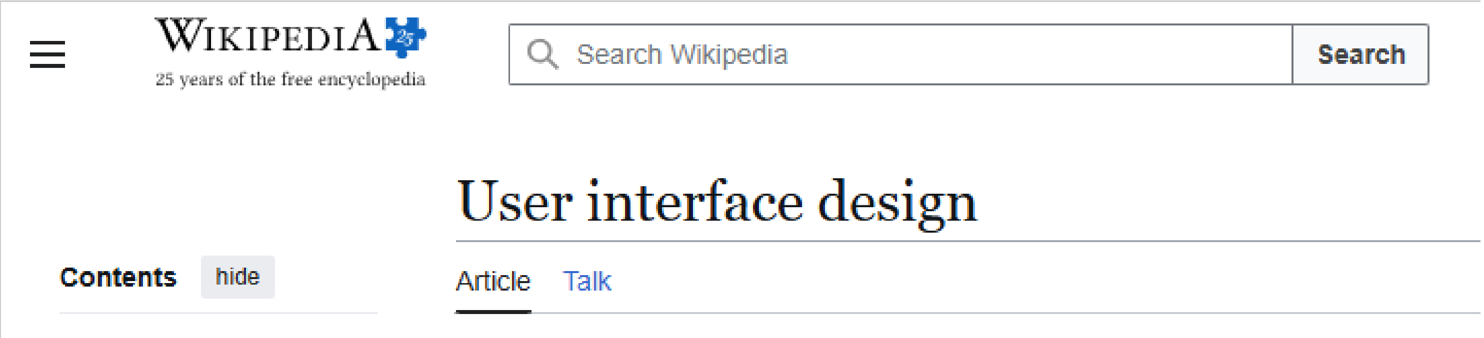
The "See also" section presents a multi-column bullet list of related links such as "Chief experience officer," "Interaction design pattern," and "Computer-mediated communication" with no categorization or visual organization. The grouping principle states that related elements should be bound together and distinguished from surrounding content through negative space, contrasts, or arrangement rather than bounding boxes. This section does not apply any of these techniques. The links appear to be organized alphabetically rather than by topic, so there are no sub-groups and no visual cues to indicate which links relate to each other. A user must read through every item to find what they are looking for. Because related links are not visually grouped, the grouping principle is violated.

4. Color-Coded Navigation Boxes (Follows Layers)



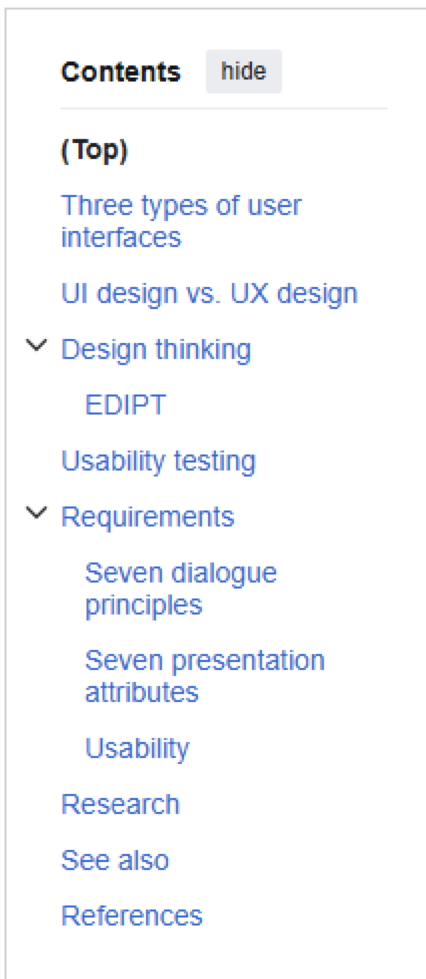
At the bottom of the article, Wikipedia uses collapsible navigation boxes labeled "User interfaces," "Design," and "Visualization of technical information." Each box has a blue-gray header bar that visually separates it from the article content above and from the other boxes. The categories bar at the bottom uses a different background shade as well. The layers principle states that contrasting color, value, and texture can segregate information into separate layers, allowing each to be read and interpreted independently. These navigation boxes apply this effectively. A user can scan the colored headers to identify the relevant topic group without needing to read the contents of the other boxes. Because the design uses color contrast to create distinct, independently readable layers, the layers principle is followed.

5. Clean Header with Minimal Clutter (Follows Simplicity)



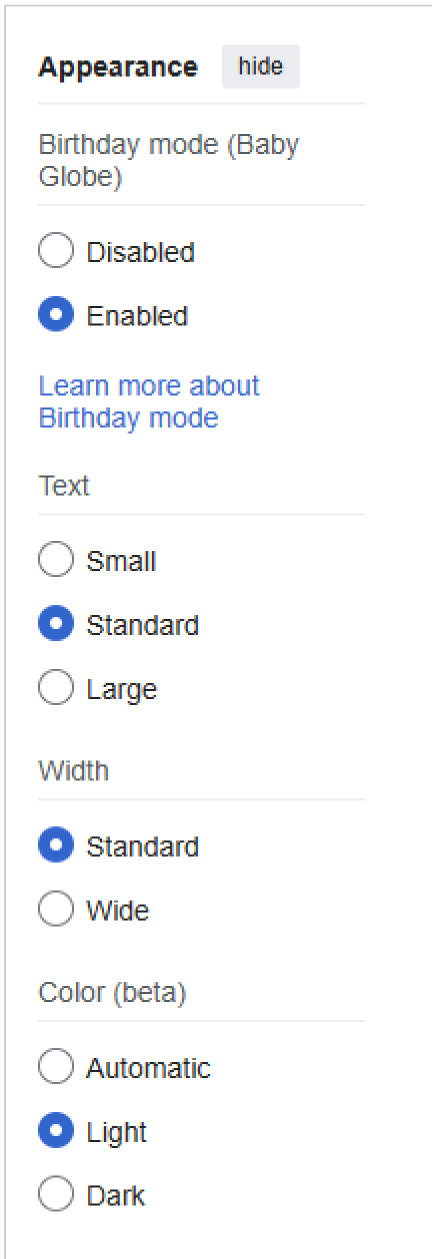
The top of the Wikipedia page displays the logo, tagline, search bar, and article title with generous spacing and no additional elements. There are no advertisements, banners, or competing interactive elements. The simplicity principle states that design should be reduced to its essence by removing inessential details until only the necessary remains. The header accomplishes this. The search bar is the primary interactive element and the article title receives clear prominence through size and spacing, with nothing else competing for attention. Because the header contains only essential elements with appropriate spacing, the simplicity principle is followed.

6. Table of Contents Indentation (Follows Gestalt Proximity)



The table of contents uses indentation and vertical spacing to communicate the relationship between sections and subsections. Top-level sections like "Design thinking" and "Requirements" are positioned at the left edge, while their subsections ("EDIPT," "Seven dialogue principles") are indented beneath them. The Gestalt principle of proximity states that elements are associated most strongly with nearby elements, and that spacing creates perceived grouping. The TOC applies this correctly. Subsections appear closer to their parent section than to the next top-level section, making the article's hierarchical structure immediately visible. Because the spacing and indentation create accurate groupings, the Gestalt proximity principle is followed.

7. Appearance Settings Panel (Follows Scale and Contrast)



The Appearance settings panel is divided into labeled groups (Birthday mode, Text, Width, Color) separated by subtle horizontal dividers. Within each group, radio button options are evenly spaced and consistently sized. The selected option is indicated by a filled blue circle that contrasts against the empty unselected circles. The scale and contrast principle states that contrasts should be clear and easily differentiated (clarity) and conscious, strong, few in number, and never overwhelming (restraint). This panel satisfies both. There are only two visual states with an obvious distinction between them, and the group labels use a lighter gray that separates them from the interactive controls without competing for attention. Because the contrasts are clear, intentional, and restrained, the scale and contrast principle is followed.